

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Finance English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

08 Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: Revenue, Operating income, Variance, Sensitivity.

Model response

Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. B - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Revenue ahead, operating profit behind - The lesson's review shows revenue 5% above budget and operating profit 2% below. The causes are not supplied.

2. Higher revenue per unit, unchanged unit sales - Separate fictional planning exercise: revenue rises from \$100,000 to \$110,000 while unit sales remain at 1,000; the revenue breakdown is available only at this level.

3. Sensitivity is a what-if, not a forecast update - Separate fictional model review: an analyst tests a 10% fuel-cost increase without changing the approved forecast assumptions.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A percentage-point correction

A fictional review reports an operating margin rising from 8% to 10%. A speaker calls that a two-percent relative increase. No causes have been investigated.

Role A: You are the finance analyst. Explain the two-percentage-point change and the different relative calculation.

Role B: You are the business manager. Paraphrase the distinction without assigning an unsupported cause.

Possible opening: The margin increased by two percentage points; that is different from a two-percent relative increase.

Success checks

- State the absolute movement as two percentage points.
- Explain that the relative increase from eight to ten is 25%.
- Keep the cause unresolved.

Add a complication: A stakeholder wants to credit automation even though no driver analysis is available.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

An invoice covers services delivered in December but was paid in January. A colleague asks which month should appear in the close schedule.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: Accrual, Deferred revenue, Working capital, Reconciliation.

Model response

Are we discussing the cash payment date or the accounting period for the expense? The payment was in January; the accounting treatment needs to follow our policy and the service details.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which month does the close schedule mean? - The lesson's invoice covers services delivered in December and paid in January; accounting treatment requires contextual review.

2. Cash received before the service begins - Separate fictional close exercise: a customer pays in advance for a future service; no revenue-recognition assessment has been completed.

3. A reconciliation difference needs a cutoff question - Separate fictional close exercise: a bank export ends Friday, while the internal cash schedule includes Monday entries.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A credit note without a linked invoice

A fictional close file contains a credit note but no linked invoice reference. Its cash settlement status and prior accounting entry are unknown.

Role A: You prepare the close schedule. Request the invoice linkage and existing-entry information before proposing treatment.

Role B: You are the billing coordinator. State what is missing and agree how to retrieve it.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which invoice this credit note relates to and whether an entry is already recorded?

Success checks

- Ask for the invoice link and prior entry.
- Preserve the unknown settlement status.
- Agree a records check rather than an unsupported accounting classification.

Add a complication: Someone suggests classifying it by the credit note's filename alone.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

The forecast shows \$120,000 of spending against a \$100,000 budget. A new supplier fee accounts for \$15,000; the remaining \$5,000 is under review.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: Budget, Forecast, Variance, Bridge.

Model response

Spending is forecast to be \$20,000 above budget. The supplier fee explains \$15,000 of that variance. We are still reviewing the remaining \$5,000 and will update the bridge tomorrow.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. A twenty-thousand-dollar bridge with a gap - The lesson's spending forecast is \$120,000 against a \$100,000 budget; \$15,000 relates to a supplier fee and \$5,000 remains under review.

2. Forecast submitted but not approved - Separate fictional planning exercise: a department submitted a revised forecast; the finance review is still pending and the budget is unchanged.

3. A timing shift is not a permanent saving - Separate fictional forecast review: \$12,000 of planned maintenance moved from March to April; the annual scope and total remain unchanged.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An incomplete headcount forecast

A fictional forecast includes salary assumptions for six planned hires, but start dates for two are unconfirmed. The approved headcount budget has not changed.

Role A: You are the planning analyst. Report completed inputs and the two unresolved start-date assumptions.

Role B: You manage recruitment. Ask how the uncertainty affects the forecast without treating it as hiring approval.

Possible opening: Six roles are modeled, but two start dates are assumptions we still need to confirm.

Success checks

- Identify two unconfirmed dates out of six roles.
- Separate forecast assumptions from approved headcount.
- Agree who will check the dates and how uncertainty remains visible.

Add a complication: A sponsor asks you to present all six start dates as agreed to simplify the update.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A cash forecast assumes a large customer pays on Friday. The customer has not confirmed payment. A manager asks if the cash balance is guaranteed.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: Liquidity, Cash runway, Revolver, FX exposure.

Model response

The forecast assumes payment on Friday; that date is not confirmed. I'll show the balance both with and without the receipt so the team can see the liquidity exposure.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Friday's receipt is still an assumption - The lesson's cash forecast assumes a large customer pays Friday; the customer has not confirmed payment.

2. An undrawn facility is not unrestricted cash - Separate fictional treasury exercise: a report lists cash and an undrawn revolver separately; availability conditions have not been reviewed.

3. A currency assumption is not a locked rate - Separate fictional forecast: a foreign-currency invoice is converted using a planning rate; no executed hedge or agreed settlement rate is supplied.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Payment reported; receipt unconfirmed

A fictional customer says a payment instruction was submitted. The receiving bank record has not been checked, and the forecast currently includes the receipt today.

Role A: You are the treasury analyst. Distinguish the customer's statement from confirmed receipt.

Role B: You are the collections lead. Ask what confirmation is needed and how to describe today's cash forecast.

Possible opening: The customer reports submitting an instruction, but we haven't confirmed receipt in our bank record.

Success checks

- Attribute the customer's report accurately.
- Keep receipt and timing unconfirmed.
- Agree a bank-record check and a qualified forecast statement.

Add a complication: A manager wants the incoming amount counted as settled cash immediately.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

CASE

A portfolio return is 6% before fees. Its benchmark returned 5% over the same stated period. A slide does not identify fee treatment.

Teach this move

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Vocabulary to check: Return, Benchmark, Volatility, Attribution.

Model response

The figures suggest a one-percentage-point difference before fees. We should label fee treatment and confirm the comparison basis before describing the performance to a client.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. 'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Second-round challenge

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Language-check answers

1. B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less. 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.
2. A - An increase of one percentage point. Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

05 • Conversations

1. Six percent before fees needs a visible label - The lesson's portfolio return is 6% before fees and the benchmark returned 5% over the same period. Benchmark treatment needs clarification.

2. Different periods cannot rank performance fairly - Separate fictional reporting exercise: fund A's summary covers twelve months, while fund B's covers six months. No matched-period figures are available.

3. A higher return with greater variation - Separate fictional training dataset: portfolios A and B have same-period, same-fee-basis returns of 7% and 6%; A's measured volatility is higher.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A return series with withdrawals

A fictional portfolio's ending balance is lower than its opening balance, and the account had a withdrawal. No calculated performance return is supplied.

Role A: You prepare performance reports. Explain why balance movement alone does not identify investment return.

Role B: You review client communication. Ask for a calculation that accounts for the cash flow and a comparable benchmark basis.

Possible opening: The balance declined, but the withdrawal means that movement is not itself the investment return.

Success checks

- Separate cash flow from investment performance.
- Do not invent an unsupplied return.
- Agree to obtain the appropriate calculation before benchmarking.

Add a complication: Someone wants to call the entire balance decline a market loss.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A credit file is missing an updated financial statement. The review team needs it for a scheduled meeting on Thursday.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: Credit risk, Collateral, DSCR, Probability of default.

Model response

Could you send the latest approved financial statements through the secure channel by Wednesday? Please confirm the reporting period, or let us know when the documents will be available.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Requesting the statement for Thursday's review - The lesson's credit file lacks an updated financial statement needed for a Thursday review meeting.

2. A collateral valuation with an unknown date - Separate fictional credit review: a collateral valuation is present, but its effective date is absent from the summary.

3. Requesting the model definition behind default risk - Separate fictional credit exercise: a dashboard shows a probability-of-default estimate with no model version or horizon stated.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Debt-service inputs need a period check

A fictional credit worksheet combines annual cash-flow figures with a quarterly debt-service figure. The correct matching-period inputs have not been obtained.

Role A: You are the credit analyst. Request matching-period inputs before relying on the DSCR calculation.

Role B: You maintain the financial file. Clarify the two periods and agree how to obtain the needed figures.

Possible opening: Could you provide debt service for the same period as the cash-flow figure before we use this ratio?

Success checks

- Identify the annual-versus-quarterly mismatch.
- Separate arithmetical calculation from a meaningful ratio.
- Request the correct inputs without inventing credit thresholds or an approval outcome.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests presenting the existing ratio because the arithmetic works.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

CASE

A reconciliation has three unmatched entries. Their cause is unknown. The preparer is handing the work to a reviewer at the end of the day.

Teach this move

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Vocabulary to check: Internal control, Control deficiency, Reconciliation, Segregation of duties.

Model response

Three entries remain unmatched. I've listed their references and the checks already completed. Please review the supporting records and record the resolution; the cause is still unconfirmed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Second-round challenge

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Language-check answers

1. C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check. It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.
2. B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct? This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

05 · Conversations

1. Three unmatched entries at handoff - The lesson's preparer hands over a reconciliation with three unmatched entries whose cause is unknown.
2. A review signature with missing evidence - Separate fictional control review: a payment file has a reviewer signature, but the referenced supporting document is absent.
3. An access overlap needs assessment - Separate fictional controls exercise: an access report shows one person can prepare and approve payments; actual use of those permissions has not been checked.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An exception report with an unchecked duplicate

A fictional payment exception report flags two records with the same invoice number. Their amounts and supplier identifiers have not been compared. No duplicate payment is confirmed.

Role A: You prepare controls reports. Hand over the flagged pair and state the unperformed checks.

Role B: You are the reviewer. Confirm the next comparison and avoid assuming fraud or duplicate payment.

Possible opening: Two records share an invoice number, but the supplier and amount checks are still pending.

Success checks

- Distinguish an exception flag from a confirmed duplicate.
- Name the missing comparisons.
- Confirm review ownership and preserve the absence of any recovery finding.

Add a complication: A manager wants the case title to say duplicate payment recovered, although no recovery occurred.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A valuation model changes materially when the growth assumption moves from 2% to 4%. The presentation shows only the higher estimate.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: DCF, WACC, Enterprise value, Sensitivity.

Model response

The valuation is sensitive to the growth assumption. I'll present both scenarios and explain the assumptions behind them. The higher figure is a modeled outcome, not an assured transaction value.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Showing both growth assumptions - The lesson's valuation changes materially between 2% and 4% growth assumptions, but the presentation shows only the higher estimate.

2. Enterprise value is not the equity proceeds - Separate fictional transaction model: a slide labels enterprise value as shareholder proceeds; debt and cash adjustments have not been assessed.

3. A lower discount rate is not new operating evidence - Separate fictional valuation exercise: cash-flow forecasts stay unchanged while an analyst lowers the model's WACC; the assumption has not been approved.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Savings enter the model before costs

A fictional acquisition model includes proposed annual savings but excludes integration costs because they have not been estimated. No net-benefit conclusion is approved.

Role A: You review the valuation. Explain the missing cost side and limit the claim.

Role B: You sponsor the acquisition analysis. Ask what estimate is needed before discussing net value.

Possible opening: The model includes proposed savings, but it cannot yet establish net benefit without integration costs.

Success checks

- Separate proposed savings from realized benefits.
- Identify unestimated integration costs.
- Agree a fuller assessment without assigning invented values or certainty.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to call the savings guaranteed value creation.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Original fictional case: Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Operating income: Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Sensitivity: Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Original fictional case: Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Operating income: Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Sensitivity: Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

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Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level